

Learn what documents you will need to get a Social Security Card | Social Security Administration

Original Card for a Noncitizen Child

In general, only noncitizens who have permission to work from the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) can apply for a Social Security number. If your child does not have permission to work but needs a Social Security number for other purposes, see "If your child does not have permission to work" for further information.

Important

You must present original documents or copies certified by the agency that issued them. We cannot accept photocopies or notarized copies. All documents must be current (not expired). We cannot accept a receipt showing you applied for the document.

Adoption

In some cases, we can assign your adopted child a number before the adoption is complete, but you may want to wait. Then, you can apply for the number using your child's new name. If you want to claim your child for tax purposes while the adoption is still pending, contact the Internal Revenue Service for Form W-7A, Application for Taxpayer Identification Number for Pending U.S. Adoptions. For more information, see Social Security Numbers For Children (Publication No. 05-10023).

What original documents do I need?

Immigration status

To prove your child's U.S. immigration status, you must show us your child's current U.S. immigration document, such as:

- I-551 (Lawful Permanent Resident Card, Machine Readable Immigrant Visa);
- I-766 (Employment Authorization Document, EAD, work permit); or
- I-94 (Arrival/Departure Record) or admission stamp in the unexpired foreign passport.

If your child is an F-1 or M-1 student, we must see your child's I-20 (Certificate of Eligibility for Nonimmigrant Student Status).

If your child is a J-1 or J-2 exchange visitor, you must see your child's DS-2019 (Certificate of Eligibility for Exchange Visitor Status).

Work eligibility

In general, only noncitizens who have permission to work from DHS can apply for a Social Security number. For most foreign workers, we only need to see an I-94 (Arrival/Departure Record) or admission stamp in the unexpired foreign passport showing a class of admission permitting work. Some foreign workers must show their I-766 (Employment Authorization Document, EAD, work permit) from DHS.

Student: If you are an F-1 student and eligible to work on campus, you must provide a letter from your designated school official that:

- Identifies you;
- Confirms your current school status; and
- Identifies your employer and the type of work you are, or will be, doing.

We also need to see evidence of that employment, such as a recent pay slip or a letter from your employer. Your supervisor must sign and date the letter. The letter must describe:

- Your job;
- Your employment start date;
- The number of hours you are, or will be, working; and
- Your supervisor's name and telephone number.

If you are an F-1 student authorized to work in curricular practical training (CPT), you must provide us your Form I-20 with the employment page completed and signed by your designated school official.

If you are an F-1 student and have a work permit (I-766) from DHS, you must present it.

If you are a J-1 student, student intern or international visitor, you must provide a letter from your sponsor. The letter should be on sponsor letterhead with an original signature that authorizes your employment.

If your child does not have permission to work: Lawfully admitted noncitizens can get many benefits and services without a Social Security number. You do not need a number to conduct business with a bank, register for school, apply for educational tests, obtain private health insurance, apply for school lunch programs or apply for subsidized housing. You cannot get a Social Security number for the sole purpose of obtaining a driver's license.

Government benefits or services: If your child does not have permission to work, the child may apply for a Social Security number only if:

- A federal law requires your child to provide a Social Security number to get a particular benefit or service; or
- A state or local law requires you to provide your Social Security number to get general assistance benefits for which you already have qualified.

If your child needs a number to meet these state or local requirements, you must bring us a letter from the government agency. It must be on letterhead stationery (no form letters or photocopies) and:

- Specifically identify your child as the applicant;
- Cite the law requiring your child to have a Social Security number;
- Indicate that your child meets all the agency's requirements, except having the number; and
- Contain an agency contact name and telephone number.

Taxes: If you need a number for your child for tax purposes and your child is not authorized to work in the United States, you can apply for an Individual Taxpayer Identification Number for your child from the Internal Revenue Service (IRS). Visit IRS in person or call the IRS toll-free number, 1-800-TAXFORM (1-800-829-3676), and request Form W-7A (Application for Taxpayer Identification Number for Pending U.S. Adoptions).

If you are assigned a number for non-work purposes, you cannot use it to work. If you use it to work, we will inform DHS.

Age

You must present your child's foreign birth certificate if you have it or can get it within 10 days. If not, we will consider other documents such as your child's passport or a document issued by DHS as evidence of your child's age.

Anyone age 12 or older requesting an original Social Security number must appear in person for an interview. We will ask for evidence to show that your child does not have a Social Security number. If your child lived outside the United States for an extended period, a current or previous passport, school and/or employment records, and any other record that would show long-term residence outside the United States could be used to show that your child does not have a Social Security number.

Identity

Your child: Social Security will ask to see your child's current DHS document. Acceptable documents include:

- I-551 Permanent Resident Card;
- I-94 Arrival/Departure Record with unexpired foreign passport; or
- I-766 Employment Authorization Document, (EAD, work permit) from DHS.

If your child does not have a current DHS document, we can accept only certain documents as proof of your child's identity. An acceptable document must show your child's name, identifying information (i.e., age, date of birth, or parents' names) and preferably a recent photograph. We generally can accept a non-photo identity document if it has enough information to identify the child (such as the child's name and age, date of birth or parents' names). We prefer to see the child's U.S. passport. If that document is not available, we may accept the child's:

- Adoption decree;
- Doctor, clinic or hospital record;
- Religious record;
- School daycare center record; or
- School identification card.

You: We also must see proof of your identity. An acceptable document must show your child's name, identifying information (i.e., age, date of birth, or parents' names) and preferably a recent photograph. For example, as proof of identity Social Security must see your:

- U. S. driver's license;
- State-issued non-driver identification card; or
- U.S. passport.

If you do not have one of these specific documents or you cannot get a replacement for one of them within 10 days, we will ask to see other documents. Any documents submitted, including the following, must be current (not expired) and show your name, identifying information (date of birth or age) and preferably a recent photograph:

- Employee identification card;
- School identification card;
- Health insurance card (not a Medicare card); or
- U.S. military identification card.

If you are not a U.S. citizen, Social Security will ask to see a current DHS document. Acceptable documents include:

- I-551 Permanent Resident Card;
- I-94 Arrival/Departure Record with unexpired foreign passport; or
- I-766 Employment Authorization Document, (EAD, work permit) from DHS.

Note

We may use one document for two purposes. For example, we may use a DHS work permit as proof of both immigration status and identity. However, you must provide at least two separate documents.